

A “User Manual” for Zac Bookman

Hi, I'm Zac! I'm the CEO and one of the Co-founders of OpenGov. This is a collection of tips and background material to understand my work style and help us achieve great things together.

While this is about me, it's not just about me. It's a glimpse at how we work at OpenGov and our cultural rhythm.

I hope this open, vulnerable, and direct communication is useful. Perhaps it will cause you to reflect on your strengths and weaknesses, and open up lines of communication within your team and across our company.

Looking forward to talking and to loads of impactful work! As always, I'd love your feedback.



ZAC BOOKMAN

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Zac Bookman". The signature is stylized, with the first name "Zac" written in a cursive-like script and the last name "Bookman" in a more formal, slightly cursive script.

About Me

When you first meet me, you'll probably notice that I'm casual and high-energy. I grew up near government, in a small town in Maryland next to Washington DC. My father worked at the National Academy of Sciences conducting oceanographic policy studies. I started a lawn-mowing business when I was eight years old and ran it until I graduated high school, but I always dreamed about the chance to sell a "product."

I studied government and politics in college, had a year in Venice Beach California (can talk about that elsewhere!), and then went to law school and did a joint master's degree in public administration. After grad school, I studied corruption in the Mexican government on a Fulbright Fellowship and then was a law clerk for a federal judge on the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Ninth Circuit.

I moved to San Francisco and spent two years practicing law at a trial litigation boutique. Highlights for me involved freeing a California prisoner on a habeas corpus petition after 18 years in jail on a wrongful double murder conviction, and obtaining asylum for a Mexican victim of domestic violence. I then went overseas to Afghanistan in late 2011 as an advisor to two U.S. Army Generals on the Anti-Corruption Task Force as a civilian contractor for the U.S. DoD. That was a surreal experience, and I wrote up one of the trips I took in a piece for the [NY Times At War Blog](#) while there.

In early 2012, while I was living in half a shipping container in Kabul, we (Joe Lonsdale, Dakin Sloss, Nate Levine, and me) started OpenGov. It was the aftermath of the Great Recession and three California cities had gone bankrupt; twelve were predicted to go bankrupt. I came home that summer and have worked at OpenGov full-time since.

We had been talking to the City of Palo Alto and the State of California about their ERP systems – the former of which had been delivered on 20 discs and had green screens while the latter was running on COBOL, the programming language most popular in the 1960s. Government officials were struggling against old tech, and we saw an opportunity to make a difference in the lives of public servants and communities.

We've made almost every mistake in the book, but it's also been an amazing adventure and a privilege to lead the journey. You can hear some of the "war" stories on various podcasts. The evolution of the product, people, and services across the organization has produced countless learnings. And I'm proud of the company we've built and particularly our mission to power more effective and accountable government. We learn, grow, and get better every day.

I work very hard, but I also like to get outside and have fun. Our marketing team did a spoof of me giving a speech on a forecast call from a ski slope or mountain somewhere. It was hilarious and kind of spot-on.

I live in San Francisco near the Presidio with my wife, Julia; our son, Freddie; a French Bulldog named Wendell; and our cat, Creole Williams.

When I'm not working, you'll find me reading (mostly non-fiction, biography, and business books these days); climbing mountains (like Denali in Alaska, Aconcagua in Argentina, or Mt. Vinson in Antarctica); doing some sport or fitness activity like trail running, yoga, cycling, swimming, or racquet sports like tennis and pickleball; or perhaps on a ski or surf trip. I love visiting other countries and learning about cultures and geography.

I'm naturally a night owl. It's not the most "professional" attribute and one I'm trying to change now that I'm a father, but I'd rather have a call at 9 pm than 7 am. I can get up when necessary, and often do so to exercise or play sports.

OpenGov and Cox

In late 2023 (closed early 2024), we decided to sell a majority stake in OpenGov to [Cox Enterprises](#), a private family conglomerate based in Atlanta, Georgia. Cox had been a longtime investor and earned the trust over the years. They had come onto our cap table through a small investment in 2021, and we built the relationship carefully. They saw what OpenGov was and could become and then underwrote for us the acquisition of Cartegraph in late 2022. Like us, they are true believers in the vision, and they saw our values in action. They had an aligned mission statement ("Leave the world a better place for the next generation") and values around investing in people, doing the right thing, and thinking long-term (among many others).

While we had been thinking that perhaps we would drive toward an IPO to provide liquidity for long-time investors and employees and funding for strategic growth, this investment allowed us to achieve those same benefits earlier than we would have otherwise achieved it (and without the high operational costs, stringent reporting, and short-term thinking). Plus, we could still go public if it is the right move for the company and our shareholders. We continue to operate as an entirely standalone company and, in my view, the transaction safeguards the mission for decades to come. 2024 was the best year we've had, and it's clear to me we are just getting started.

My Strengths and Weaknesses

Here's how I think our colleagues would describe me at my best as a CEO:

- Mission-Driven
- Charismatic
- Passionate
- Eloquent
- Strategic
- Visionary
- Inspiring

My strengths: company strategy, high-level issue spotting, organizational development, recruiting, selling, fundraising, M&A, and general problem-solving. I tend to have good instincts about what will and won't grow our business.

My superpower is probably the ability to build energy and excitement. I love selling prospects on our software and rooting on our R&D teams as they build out our ERP and the critical features we need across our suites. I encourage our managers to be strong leaders, use their best judgment, drive value for shareholders and customers, hold high standards, and recruit superstars. I love celebrating wins and believe momentum breeds momentum, which is something I learned from our Chairman Emeritus and co-founder Joe Lonsdale. I like engaging with our field teams and customers to understand their priorities and problems, and feeding that back into our organization.

I'm not as strong operationally or managerially. I prefer to stay out of day-to-day people and project management. I think these are extremely important and I need to be aligned culturally on how we build and operate, but I try to hire experts who love these areas to balance me (and the business) out. While it might not be my strongest suit, I am always game to roll up my sleeves, pick up the phone, and provide coaching or advice.

How I Work

Communicating with Me (and Others)

I like to give and receive open and direct feedback. Please let me know if I'm annoying you or have offended you or do something that you love, and I'll try to do the same. I like positive reinforcement and love to give it. I need critical feedback to get better. It can be hard to hear, but it's a gift. I'll assume you see it the same way.

I love written updates. I take in information most effectively through reading, and I can't run the business effectively if I don't know what's going on. Reading is the most efficient form of data exchange. Have I mentioned that I love written updates?

I expect a pre-read for meetings. I don't like being invited to a meeting with no agenda and then having someone read a deck to me. It's a waste of time, and I can't read and listen (let alone discuss) at the same time.

Updates should be a function of time passing, not work product completion. Many people misunderstand this. Look at public companies, for example: they are required to report quarterly and annually. They don't say "Nothing to report, so we can skip the earnings call."

When I'm stressed, uninformed, or concerned about a lack of progress, I can raise the temperature in a way that can be unproductive. You'll know this is happening when you see me micromanaging, involving myself at a really detailed level, and bypassing owners or leaders to give operational or management direction. The best way to help avoid this is to keep me fully posted. Manage me! If you are not done with a project, write a note and say "Hey, I'm not done with this, but it's on my radar and underway." That lets your teammates

and me know you're in charge and will get things done. It calms my cortisol trigger and makes me think, "Great, this person is on it."

The best way to engage me (or your boss) for a project is at the 20–30% mark, so that we can offer input and feedback and ensure it's headed in the right direction. Engage again at the 80–90% mark so that I/we can do a 'copy-edit' or give more granular feedback. It is almost never a good idea to pull the curtain off a project and say "Voila, this is 100% done, don't you like it?"

Many people say "I don't want to write you and flood your inbox." I'd prefer to worry about my time, my feelings, and my inbox; and you can worry about yours. That, in conjunction with open and direct feedback, reduces "walking on eggshells" and helps get good work done.

Simply put: overcommunicate.

If you notice the temperature rising, here is what you should do:

1. Don't be intimidated by my communication style. I genuinely want to know when you disagree with me and why you feel that way. It's much better if/when you're right! If I'm right and something is wrong, then I feel validated for going deep and frustrated that it wasn't surfaced earlier.
2. Listen to my concerns and reiterate them to me. If we are not aligned, we'll likely have discovered a key issue or problem that we can solve as a company. And if we are, I'll be relieved to know that brainpower is being applied to the problem set.
3. Come back to me with a solution, plan, and regular updates.

I'm a human and I have bad days like others; this is when I'm most prone to have a poor tone. I can sound like I'm upset or even patronizing. My coach (yes, I have a coach!) has a theory that stress is the manifestation of confusion and the purpose of conflict is to gain clarity over the reality of a situation. In other words, I'm often not actually angry. I'm working hard to minimize my reactivity and to limit any side effects when this behavior comes up, including by noting it here.

For all my many faults, I think I'd be characterized as forgiving. I try not to hold grudges and often find that conflict actually builds trust. Many times I've had a seemingly negative interaction, at work or personally, and end up building a friendship by resolving it positively. My thought process is: "How can I apologize if I've done something wrong? How can we have an argument, and then put our arms on one another's shoulders afterward and shake it off?"

I have strong opinions, weakly held. I'm fine with, and even encouraged by, good debate. Arguing comes almost naturally. I don't have great manners, for better and mostly worse. Often, I'll state a position and it sounds imperative. It's usually not. If you have a better argument, I'm likely to adopt it. Many, many people at OpenGov have earned raises and promotions by disagreeing repeatedly and being right. I would say we depend on this!

There are three hats a CEO can wear: Hat 1) a command or mandate, Hat 2) a suggestion based on experience and judgment, and Hat 3) one opinion among many. I am almost always speaking while wearing Hat 2 or Hat 3. I'll try to make it clear if I'm ever speaking while wearing Hat 1, and there is no harm in asking if there's ever any confusion.

Working with Me (and Others)

Please feel free to pull me into things like strategy and planning, sales calls or customer challenges, anything marketing and branding, product or metrics reviews, or even fun things like SDR call competitions and happy hours.

When you pull me in, let me know what my role is and what you expect from me. Am I approving? Am I being informed? Am I just there to build team spirit? All are good—I just want to do a good job for you and the team. If you are doing an offsite at SF HQ, please give me a heads up. I'd love to do a Q&A with the team or hang out a bit.

If you want to schedule a meeting with me, please email me directly with my Executive Assistant and Chief of Staff cc'd. Always happy to hear from you!

My management style would probably be called "collaborative," and I rarely use "command and control." I am often casual in my delivery of work assignments, but I expect all of us to deliver on time and with a high level of quality and professionalism. If you're unclear on timing or expectations, please ask.

I'm very responsive. Perhaps I learned it from Joe Lonsdale, who is the fastest email responder I know. If you send me a note or give me a call, I will write back or call back. I think it's important to stay connected, and it's a matter of respect for all the incredible people here doing hard and important work every day. I don't want to be a bottleneck, and we are very responsive to one another as teammates.

I'm cool with, and even like, spontaneous calls and texts. If you get a win, feel free to share it. Good news is fun. Everyone likes to work with, buy from, and support winning teams.

I use exclams to convey energy and enthusiasm! Those qualities resonate in sales contexts, whether with prospects and customers or recruits. Give it a try:) I like to promote our win right in emails with a postscript like "P.S. Three governments signed on to OpenGov today!" If something's off or wrong, please share that too. It's best to surface tough news fast so we can lean on one another and work through it.

Sometimes, I'll just ping you or ask how you're doing. It's not a test. I'm just seeing how you're doing and if there's anything I can do to support or help.

Lastly, use the first-person plural: "We" not "you" if you are a new employee. We are one team on a big mission. There are no outsiders among teammates and no time for folks to stand on the sidelines. We all have to pull together and fly in formation.

What Matters to Me

Our mission, vision, and values:

- Our mission is to power more effective and accountable government. Our vision is high-performance government for every community.
- Our values are Build the Trust, Live our Mission, Act with Urgency, Learn and Grow, and Win as One
- I care about having a big impact, winning for all of our stakeholders, and doing right by everyone we deal with.
- I love closing deals, deploying new customers, shipping new software, improving our processes, hiring top talent, and building the company up brick by brick. Hitting milestones and keeping score on our revenue, cash burn, gross retention, sales efficiency, and other key metrics of business value and success are inextricably linked for me with the mission, vision, and values. It's the beauty of a mission-driven business: Each small win is one step further in powering more effective and accountable government.

Positivity, can-do attitude, humor, enthusiasm, and growth mindset.

- Our work is so hard that it's nice to have some levity, and it's key to stay optimistic. Enthusiasm, in particular, is a long-term winning trait.
- See [How I Raised Myself from Failure to Success in Selling](#). It's a classic, and I can send you a book report on it if helpful (my brother has a book club in which we write a one-pager on each book we read—I'll occasionally attach some to company updates).
- I am committed to learning and improving. I admire so many of the "learners" at OpenGov. Few things give me more pride than watching talent at the company rise and build skills, take on new challenges, and grow their careers and those of others.

Bias to action and urgency.

- It may be cliché, but it's often better to ask forgiveness rather than permission – provided you're right! Get after it.
- We delight (and almost shock) our customers, and our teammates, with how responsive we are and how much we care. I want us to be known for bizarrely good customer service and internal speed.

Being right matters.

- Exercise good judgment. Gather the facts. Listen to customers and colleagues. It's okay to make mistakes. Try not to make them twice, and definitely not three times. As Bezos has said, "Leaders are right a lot... They seek diverse perspectives and work to disconfirm their beliefs."

Can you negotiate?

- I like working with people who are scrappy, who hustle, who barter, and who find and create win-win situations. I hate injustice and being ripped off, personally or for our company. I like good value, but I also know that good deals should have both parties winning and leaving feeling like winners.

Running toward confrontation.

- I like finding our problems, and I see the good in conflict. It's the job of a leader and manager to confront issues. As I sometimes say, "work is one long series of awkward conversations." We get better by finding, and solving, problems
- The first step in problem-solving is routing problems to the right people. Who is assigned ownership of the problem by virtue of their job description? Have you told them? Two people typically can't or shouldn't own the same decision. If that's the case, move up a level on the org chart until you find the "owner." We must hold one another accountable for making decisions and cleaning up messes.
- See Frank Slietman's article [Amp It Up](#). Please read that article.
- Marc Andreessen has great advice: you can judge a manager by his or her ability to "manage conflict." Ben Horowitz encourages you to [do the hard thing](#).

What I Don't Have Patience For

Sloppy work and lack of critical thinking.

It's important to understand what we're doing with respect to our mission, vision, values, and business strategy. If you don't feel like you understand, speak up. Talk to your manager, talk to members of our leadership team, talk to me.

We have to move at the speed of business—so not everything needs triple proofreading and perfection. As a recovering lawyer, I've learned that the hard way! That said, we want our customers to leave their interactions with us saying "wow, what a company." And the more we impress our colleagues, the higher the bar goes for the whole team.

Low effort and non-responsiveness.

If something is wrong, talk to your manager. Never take the ball and stop dribbling or grab it and go home. We count on one another. So we need to stay connected and GSD.

Gossip.

If there's a problem, bring it to your manager, HR, or me. Be proactive in solving it. There's no problem we can't overcome if we have the company's best interest in mind. [Five Dysfunctions of a Team](#) is required reading. We do not keep secrets about the company from our bosses or leadership – period. If you don't understand this, and you have read Five Dysfunctions of a Team, please come talk to me and I will explain our views on trust.

(Basically: “Do you trust me enough to talk to me? If not, we probably shouldn’t work together”).

Misalignment.

Alignment is when all oars are rowing in the same direction. If we are all headed to “Detroit,” then any discussion is about how to best get to “Detroit.” If some people are going to “San Diego” while others are going to “Detroit,” we are not going to go anywhere fast. Lack of alignment slows down productivity dramatically. Given execution is a function of alignment, our job is to create alignment.

If you see a team or teammates that don’t agree on basic things or fundamental questions or directions, please talk about it. “Locking ourselves in a room” is often a good way to get an agreed-upon plan, including plans where some folks “disagree and commit.” It’s okay not to agree. It’s not okay to not say you disagree, if that’s how you feel. We value people who can disagree, commit, and move forward.

Obfuscation or lack of directness.

I never have to question someone’s honesty or integrity. And I would rather know what lies ahead of us, no matter how cumbersome. Bad news does not get better with age. Please don’t not tell me something vague or “diplomatic” or euphemistic for the sake of my “feelings.” And if you don’t want to tell me something for fear of how I will react, we now have two problems: a) the issue you wanted to talk about and b) my reactivity (or your projection), which is impeding our progress. Let’s talk about both.

Conclusion

This is a living, breathing document. I’d like it to evolve with your feedback, including as you know me and see things that I am likely to miss. I hope this is helpful to you and your teams, including new employees who are trying to learn our culture and make a big impact.

We are building an incredible company. The more self-awareness, openness, and empathy we exercise, the stronger we will get. We’ve got the right strategy; immense drive and ambition; great people; innovative, category-leading software; and a strong culture and powerful mission. Amping up our communications and aligning behind these values and this culture will unlock our ability to achieve the mission to power more effective and accountable government and realize our vision of high-performance government for every community.